ROALLA



EXECUTIVE GROWTH LEADERSHIP DECISION GUIDE

COO Readiness and Operating Leadership

Determine whether the company needs a COO and define the operating system the role must lead

Prepared for founders, owners, boards, chief executives, investors and functional leaders in growth companies

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Purpose

This guide helps owners and CEOs distinguish a true need for enterprise operating leadership from a general desire for help. It defines the COO mandate around execution, cross-functional performance, operating rhythm, scale and accountability—without turning the role into a catch-all for everything the CEO does not want to own.

EXECUTIVE DECISION DASHBOARD

Management View at a Glance

A COO is valuable when cross-enterprise execution has become a distinct leadership accountability. The role should own an operating system and measurable outcomes, not miscellaneous administration. CEO and COO authority must be unambiguous.

Executive question	ROALLA view	Decision implication
Does a busy CEO automatically need a COO?	**NO**	First determine whether workload reflects delegation, talent or true enterprise complexity.
Should all functions report to the COO?	**NO**	Reporting should follow mandate and decision effectiveness.
Is the COO primarily an administrator?	**NO**	The role should create enterprise operating leverage and execution reliability.
Can a COO compensate for unclear strategy?	**NO**	Operating excellence cannot replace strategic choice.
What should management authorize now?	**PURSUE**	A COO readiness assessment and operating-accountability map.

Recommended Management Posture

Use the decision model to convert management confidence into verified evidence, explicit ownership and sequenced action. A weighted score supports prioritization, but a material hard-gate failure should override an attractive average.

Questions to Put to the Leadership Team

1. Which enterprise execution outcomes currently have no owner?
2. What portion of CEO overload is solvable through delegation?
3. Which CEO decisions would transfer to the COO?
4. What should never fall into the COO mandate?
5. Which operating processes create the greatest customer or margin friction?
6. Do functional leaders have sufficient authority and capability?
7. What measures should change if the COO is effective?
8. How will the CEO-COO relationship be reviewed?

EXECUTIVE DECISION MODEL

The Eight COO Readiness Gates

These gates distinguish a needed executive accountability from an attractive title. Use them to test mandate, authority, capacity, interfaces and evolution before recruiting or reorganizing.

Stage	Gate	Required conclusion	Decision evidence
01	Need	Operating complexity requires executive ownership	Growth friction, service variation, dependencies and CEO load
02	Mandate	The COO outcome is explicit	Execution, scale, margin, quality and enterprise rhythm
03	Authority	CEO and COO decisions are separated	Strategy, people, investment, performance and escalation
04	System	Core operations can be managed end to end	Processes, owners, service levels, data and controls
05	Cadence	Management converts priorities into action	Plans, reviews, decisions, issues and follow-through
06	Measures	Performance is visible and actionable	Customer, delivery, quality, cost, capacity and risk
07	Leadership	Functional leaders remain accountable	Spans, interfaces, coaching and succession
08	Evolution	The role fits the next growth stage	Expansion, integration, transformation and future structure

Decision Rule

A failed hard gate moves the initiative to Prepare or Monitor. A strong narrative, senior sponsor or attractive market cannot replace missing authority, evidence, delivery capacity or operating control.

SECTION 01

Readiness Framework

Translate ambition into a shared executive view of value, evidence, capability and risk.



MANAGEMENT ASSESSMENT MODEL

Readiness Dimensions

No.	Decision area	Management evidence	Status
01	Operating need	Complexity, bottlenecks, variability and CEO load	**Confirmed / Developing / Gap**
02	COO mandate	Enterprise outcomes, authority and boundaries	**Confirmed / Developing / Gap**
03	Operating system	Processes, owners, standards and controls	**Confirmed / Developing / Gap**
04	Management cadence	Planning, reviews, decisions and escalation	**Confirmed / Developing / Gap**
05	Performance insight	Measures, forecasts, capacity and corrective action	**Confirmed / Developing / Gap**
06	Leadership leverage	Functional ownership, delegation and succession	**Confirmed / Developing / Gap**

Evidence Standard

Assessments should distinguish verified evidence from management confidence. Where evidence is incomplete, record the gap, owner, completion date and decision that depends on it.

STRATEGIC READINESS DEPENDENCIES

What Readiness Depends On

Dependency	Why it matters	Evidence management should expect
Need	Operating complexity requires executive ownership	Growth friction, service variation, dependencies and CEO load
Mandate	The COO outcome is explicit	Execution, scale, margin, quality and enterprise rhythm
Authority	CEO and COO decisions are separated	Strategy, people, investment, performance and escalation
System	Core operations can be managed end to end	Processes, owners, service levels, data and controls
Cadence	Management converts priorities into action	Plans, reviews, decisions, issues and follow-through
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ROALLA Interpretation

Dependencies should be evaluated as a connected system. A weakness in ownership, data, architecture, delivery or governance can change the economics and risk of an otherwise attractive initiative.

SECTION 02

Detailed Readiness Assessment

Convert executive intent into verifiable requirements, accountable evidence and clear remediation actions.



READINESS CHECKLIST

COO Need and Mandate Readiness

Completion standard Mark Ready only when the supporting evidence has been verified. Assign an evidence owner to every open item.

Gate	Readiness requirement	Ready	Gap	Evidence owner
A01	The company can identify persistent enterprise execution problems a COO would own.	☐	☐	_____
A02	CEO workload has been separated into delegation gaps, talent gaps and true executive accountabilities.	☐	☐	_____
A03	The COO mandate has measurable operating outcomes.	☐	☐	_____
A04	CEO and COO authorities are clear for strategy, people, investment and performance.	☐	☐	_____
A05	Functional executives remain accountable rather than outsourcing ownership upward.	☐	☐	_____
A06	Core customer and operational value streams have named owners.	☐	☐	_____
A07	Operating variability, rework and escalation are evidenced with data.	☐	☐	_____
A08	The role has access to the information needed to manage performance.	☐	☐	_____
A09	The candidate profile matches the company's stage and transformation agenda.	☐	☐	_____
A10	The board or owner understands how CEO-COO partnership will be governed.	☐	☐	_____

READINESS CHECKLIST CONTINUED

Operating System and Leadership Controls

Completion standard Use Gap to create a dated remediation action and identify the management decision that cannot proceed.

Gate	Readiness requirement	Ready	Gap	Evidence owner
B01	Annual priorities translate into quarterly operating commitments.	☐	☐	_____
B02	Management forums distinguish decisions, performance review and issue resolution.	☐	☐	_____
B03	A small set of enterprise measures exposes customer, delivery, cost and risk outcomes.	☐	☐	_____
B04	Cross-functional dependencies have owners and escalation thresholds.	☐	☐	_____
B05	Process standards allow controlled variation where customers or markets require it.	☐	☐	_____
B06	Capacity and resource trade-offs are made across functions rather than locally.	☐	☐	_____
B07	Functional leaders have delegated authority and clear performance expectations.	☐	☐	_____
B08	Transformation initiatives are integrated into operating cadence.	☐	☐	_____
B09	The first 100 days focus on fact base, relationships, operating rhythm and priority bottlenecks.	☐	☐	_____
B10	The COO mandate is reviewed as scale, geography and leadership depth change.	☐	☐	_____

WEIGHTED EXECUTIVE ASSESSMENT

Readiness Scorecard

Dimension	Weight	Evidence standard	Score	Status
Operating need	20%	Complexity, bottlenecks, variability and CEO load	__/20	Strong / Developing / Gap
COO mandate	20%	Enterprise outcomes, authority and boundaries	__/20	Strong / Developing / Gap
Operating system	15%	Processes, owners, standards and controls	__/15	Strong / Developing / Gap
Management cadence	15%	Planning, reviews, decisions and escalation	__/15	Strong / Developing / Gap
Performance insight	15%	Measures, forecasts, capacity and corrective action	__/15	Strong / Developing / Gap
Leadership leverage	15%	Functional ownership, delegation and succession	__/15	Strong / Developing / Gap
TOTAL	100%	Weighted executive assessment	__/100	Pursue / Prepare / Monitor

Decision Thresholds

Score	Posture	Management decision
75 to 100	**PURSUE**	Proceed to bounded execution subject to no hard-gate failure.
50 to 74	**PREPARE**	Complete a focused readiness plan before major commitment.
0 to 49	**MONITOR**	Resolve foundational gaps before investing further.

A single material hard-gate failure overrides the weighted score. ROALLA also applies judgment where administrative readiness is high but strategic value, adoption or commercial viability is weak.

SECTION 03

Execution and Advisory Roadmap

Build evidence and decision clarity before changing titles or recruiting. Use the first 90 days to prove the COO mandate and operating model in the company's real operating context.



Recommended 90 Day Mobilization

Timing	Focus	Key activities	Management output
Days 1 to 15	Clarify	Confirm growth objectives, current COO mandate and operating model, decision pressure and executive sponsor.	Approved diagnostic mandate
Days 16 to 35	Assess	Interview leaders, review evidence, map accountabilities and identify hard gaps.	Current-state evidence map
Days 36 to 55	Design	Develop practical options with mandate, interfaces, capacity, economics and risk.	Decision-ready options
Days 56 to 75	Validate	Test the preferred model through real decisions, management forums and team feedback.	Validated leadership model
Days 76 to 90	Mobilize	Approve owners, measures, communication, transition actions and review dates.	90-day activation plan

Twelve to Twenty Four Month Path

- Quarter 1: clarify the COO mandate and operating model, decision rights, interfaces and immediate capacity gaps.
- Quarter 2: embed management cadence, measures, delegation and leadership-team working practices.
- Quarters 3 and 4: adjust spans, roles and succession as scale and complexity increase.
- Year 2: review executive architecture against strategy, performance, risk and the next growth stage.

ROALLA ADVISORY MODEL

How ROALLA Can Help

ROALLA brings an independent transformation and technology perspective to operating leadership and COO readiness. The objective is a leadership system that converts strategy into accountable decisions, scalable execution and measurable enterprise value.

ROALLA workstream	Executive value
Executive diagnostic	Assess strategy, growth stage, operating complexity, leadership load and material gaps.
Mandate design	Define outcomes, scope, authority, decision rights and explicit non-accountabilities.
Operating model	Align functions, forums, information flows, escalation paths and management cadence.
Technology and product alignment	Connect architecture, delivery, product, commercial and operational leadership.
Role and capacity options	Compare combined, fractional, interim and full-time structures using evidence.
Scorecards and incentives	Translate enterprise priorities into balanced executive outcomes and measures.
Selection and onboarding	Build role briefs, evaluation criteria, interview evidence and first-100-day plans.
Evolution assurance	Monitor effectiveness, challenge gaps and reset roles as strategy and scale change.

Recommended Initial Mandate

- Four-week executive structure and accountability diagnostic.
- Decision-rights map and leadership capacity assessment.
- Recommended COO mandate and operating model with role mandates, interfaces and transition risks.
- Executive readout and 90-day activation roadmap.

CONTROL FRAMEWORK

Key Risks and Controls

Risk	Exposure	ROALLA control
Catch-all role	Unowned work accumulates under the COO.	Define outcomes and explicit exclusions.
Shadow CEO	Authority overlaps and leaders shop for answers.	Publish CEO-COO decision rights.
Functional abdication	Leaders send accountability upward.	Keep functional outcomes and measures intact.
Process bureaucracy	Standardization slows the business.	Govern only value-critical work.
Metric overload	Reporting replaces decisions.	Use a small decision-linked scorecard.
Operator without strategy	Execution optimizes the wrong priorities.	Connect cadence to strategic choices.
Change fatigue	Too many initiatives compete for capacity.	Use portfolio sequencing and stop decisions.
Succession ambiguity	The role is treated as automatic CEO successor.	Discuss succession separately and explicitly.

Professional Advice

Qualified legal, privacy, security, tax, accounting, employment and regulatory advisors should validate matters within their professional scope. ROALLA coordinates those inputs with technology strategy, architecture, commercialization, governance and transformation decisions.

OFFICIAL EVIDENCE BASE

Selected Official Sources

These sources support the management principles summarized in this guide. Standards, laws, guidance and organizational obligations continue to evolve and must be confirmed for the specific context before acting.

McKinsey Products and Platforms Operating Model. Official source — Guidance on durable product and platform teams, end-to-end ownership, funding and outcome accountability.

McKinsey The Big Product and Platform Shift. Official source — Research on leadership alignment, business and technology collaboration, talent and transformation execution.

Microsoft Cloud Adoption Framework RACI Alignment. Official source — Examples for assigning accountable, responsible, consulted and informed roles across strategy, governance, platforms and operations.

Advisory Disclaimer

This ROALLA guide is a strategic readiness and marketing document. It is not a certification, audit opinion, legal opinion, privacy opinion, security assurance, investment recommendation or guarantee of results. Management must validate current obligations, company facts and professional advice before making material decisions.